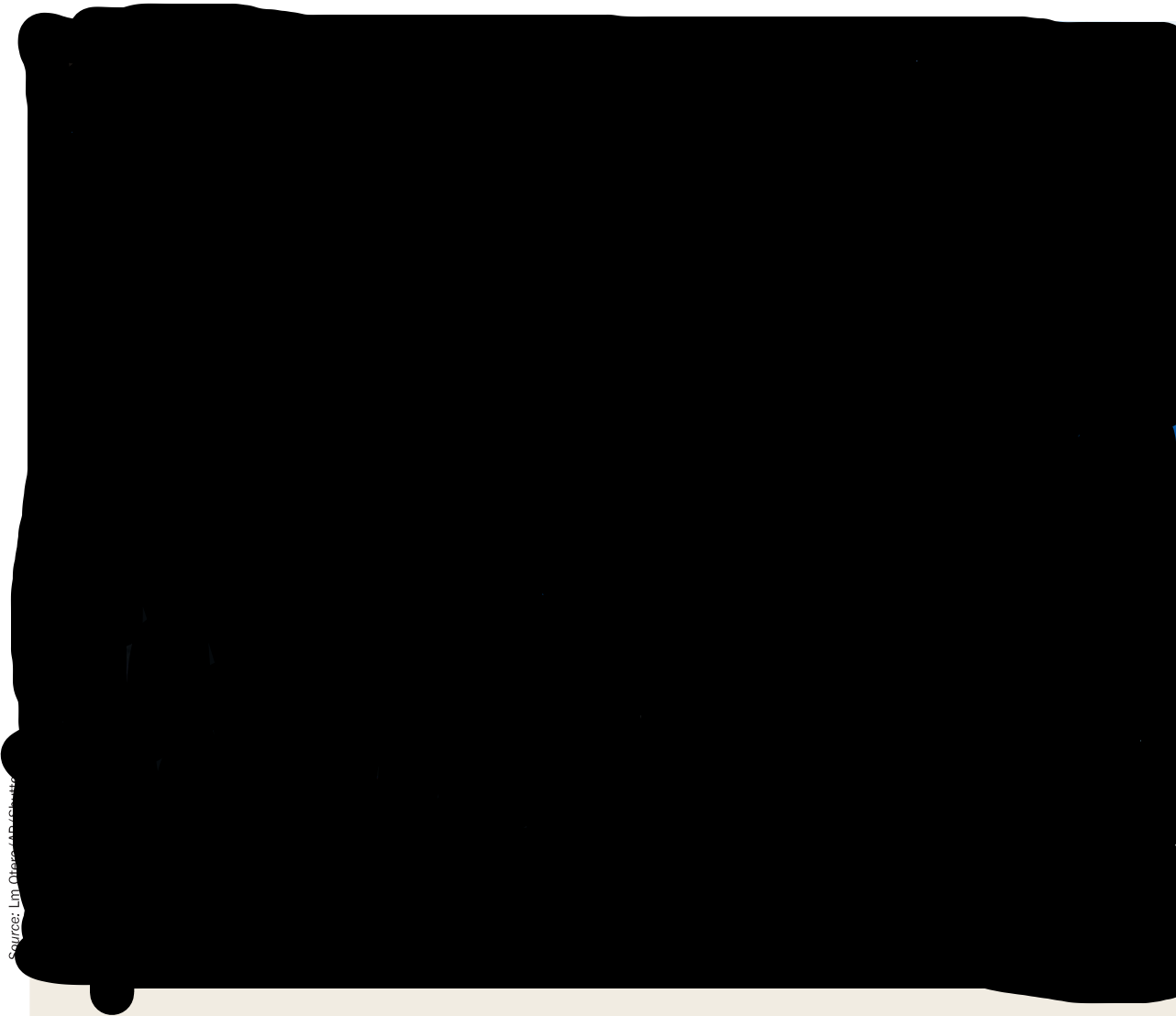


4

Emotions and Moods



Source: Lm Online/Alamy

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

After studying this chapter, you should be able to:

- | | |
|--|---|
| 4-1 Differentiate between emotions and moods. | 4-4 Describe affective events theory. |
| 4-2 Identify the sources of emotions and moods. | 4-5 Describe emotional intelligence. |
| 4-3 Show the impact emotional labor has on employees. | 4-6 Identify strategies for emotion regulation. |
| | 4-7 Apply concepts about emotions and moods to specific OB issues. |

Employability Skills Matrix (ESM)

	Myth or Science?	An Ethical Choice	Point/Counterpoint	Toward a Better World	Experiential Exercise	Ethical Dilemma	Case Incident
Critical Thinking & Creativity	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Communication	✓		✓	✓			✓
Collaboration							✓
Self-Management	✓		✓		✓		✓
Social Responsibility	✓			✓		✓	
Leadership		✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	
Career Management	✓					✓	✓

BRINGING YOUR SENSE OF HUMOR TO WORK

Southwest Airlines is known for its distinctive, unconventional culture. Apart from its unique ways of doing things, Southwest Airlines also prioritizes its employees. The company's philosophy is that employees will treat customers well if they are also treated well and that, in the end, it will benefit the business. Throughout its forty-four-year history, the company has cultivated a culture that is both inclusive and fun. Southwest's core values include "Don't take yourself too seriously" and "Don't be a jerk." The late founder and CEO, Herb Kelleher, exemplified these values. Kelleher was not afraid to make fun of himself and demonstrated that you should not have to leave your sense of humor at the office door. Leaders like Kelleher who have a sense of humor have been found to be 27 percent more motivating and admired than those without one. Kelleher himself believed that the intangibles were often more important than the tangibles. In his mind, a competitor could easily buy the tangibles, like faster airplanes, but excellent customer service or an organizational culture could not be purchased. The runway toward these intangibles is through allowing employees to express themselves authentically.

As a result of this culture, Southwest flight attendants have become well known for expressing their sense of humor and spreading joy among employees and customers alike. Although Southwest is not known for having the most luxurious in-flight experience, the employees still make it an enjoyable experience for customers. For example, employees have set up

and played “gate games” to entertain customers when there are flight delays. The airline also has flight attendant announcements that resemble comedy sketches. Southwest’s philosophy seems to be working. Glassdoor listed Southwest as one of the top twenty-five places to work in 2021. Research also supports the company’s approach, demonstrating that workplaces in which employees feel comfortable expressing their feelings are more likely to be creative, innovative, and productive. In this environment, employees are more likely to be friendly with one another, which significantly impacts employee performance.

The organization’s commitment to employee and customer well-being continued during the COVID-19 pandemic. Since its beginnings in 1971, the company has never had to institute layoffs. However, Southwest (and the rest of the airline industry) faced incredible financial challenges in the pandemic’s wake. With the threat of layoffs and pay cuts looming, employees experience extreme uncertainty and job insecurity. This insecurity can lead them to experience burdensome negative emotions resulting in emotion regulation difficulties. Demonstrating the company’s commitment to employees, CEO Gary Kelly reduced his base salary to zero and instituted a 20 percent cut in senior executives’ pay to reduce and hopefully avoid layoffs.¹

Employee emotions cannot be separated from work. They can enhance the employee and customer experience just as well as they can curtail it. Given the obvious role emotions play in our lives, it might surprise you that the field of organizational behavior (OB) has not given emotions much attention until relatively recently. Why? Historically, researchers, theorists, and practitioners thought emotions would be detrimental to performance. Although managers knew emotions were an inseparable part of everyday life, they tried to create emotion-free organizations. Researchers tended to focus on strong negative emotions—especially anger—that interfered with an employee’s ability to work effectively.

Thankfully, this type of thinking has changed with the advent of the “Affective Revolution” in OB that is still underway.² Indeed, some emotions can hinder performance, particularly those exhibited at the wrong time. Other emotions are neutral, and some are constructive. Employees bring their emotions to work every day, so no study of OB would be comprehensive without considering the role of emotions in workplace behavior.

What Are Emotions and Moods?

4-1 Differentiate between emotions and moods.

Emotions can greatly influence our attitudes toward others, our decision making, and our behaviors. They can even spark conflict with potentially disastrous consequences. For example, after being told to “stop being a crybaby,” one Florida Taco Bell employee threw a hot bean burrito at the supervisor, snapped their headset in two, and stormed out of the building.³ In truth, we are human and cannot set aside our emotions, but we *can* acknowledge and work with them. And not all emotions have negative influences on us. For example, Fausto

Martinez was delighted after finding out about Amazon's minimum wage hike. Martinez looked forward to a better quality of life, more time with family, and the lack of a need for a second full-time job.⁴ By increasing the minimum wage, Amazon improved the quality of life of its employees and stayed competitive with regard to retaining them.

First, we need to discuss three closely intertwined terms: *affect*, *emotions*, and *moods*. **Affect** is a generic term covering a broad range of feelings, including emotions and moods.⁵ **Emotions** are intense, discrete, and short-lived, often caused by a specific event.⁶ **Moods** are longer-lived and less intense feelings than emotions. They often arise without a specific event acting as a stimulus.⁷ Exhibit 4-1 shows the relationships among affect, emotions, and moods.

As the exhibit shows, affect is a broad term that encompasses emotions and moods. Affect varies by its valence, or the degree to which the feelings are positive (e.g., excited, happy, joyous) or negative (e.g., sad, angry, frustrated). Second, there are differences between emotions and moods. Emotions are more likely to be caused by a specific event and are more fleeting than moods.

Positive and Negative Affect

As a first step toward studying moods and emotions in the workplace, we classify affect into two categories: positive and negative. Positive emotions—such as joy and gratitude—express a favorable evaluation or feeling. Negative emotions—such as anger and guilt—express the opposite. We can think of **positive affect** (PA) as a dimension consisting of positive emotions such as excitement, enthusiasm, and elation at the high end (high positive affect). **Negative affect** (NA) is a dimension consisting of nervousness, stress, and anxiety at the high end (high negative affect).⁸

Exhibit 4-2 illustrates *the affective circumplex*, which categorizes and arranges emotions by their degree of positivity and negativity.⁹ In Exhibit 4-2, solid black lines directly correspond with PA and NA (e.g., emotions that directly correspond with PA or NA). For example, elated is a high positive affect emotion,

affect A term used to describe a broad range of feelings that people experience, including emotions and moods.

emotions Intense, discrete, and short-lived feeling experiences, often caused by a specific event.

moods Feelings that tend to be longer-lived and less intense than emotions and that lack a contextual stimulus.

positive affect An affective dimension that consists of specific positive emotions such as excitement, enthusiasm, and elation at the high end.

negative affect An affective dimension that consists of emotions such as nervousness, stress, and anxiety at the high end.

Exhibit 4-1 Affect, Emotions, and Moods

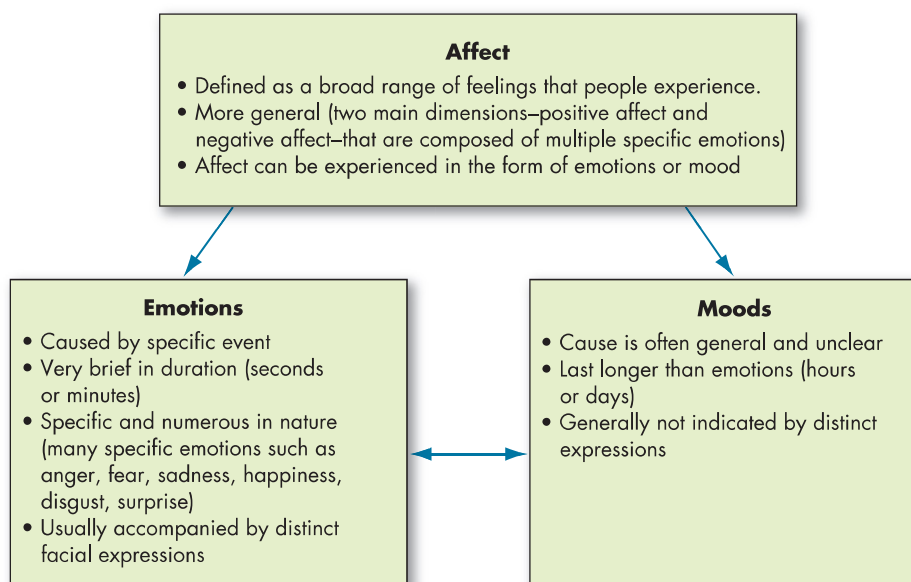
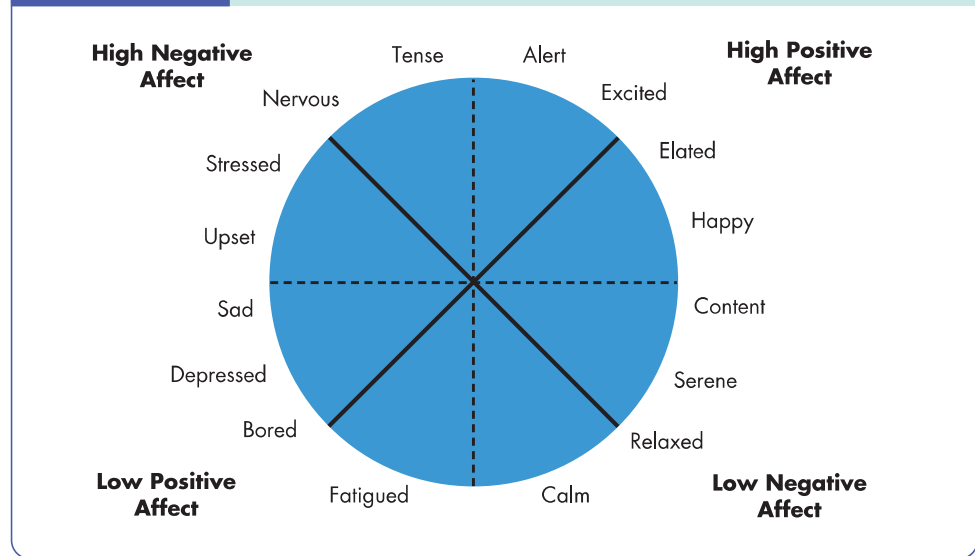


Exhibit 4-2**The Affective Circumplex**

while bored is a low positive affect emotion. Nervous is a high negative affect emotion, while relaxed is a low negative affect emotion. Finally, some emotions are “in between.” The dotted lines, on the other hand, demonstrate that some emotions can be simultaneously high or low in PA or NA. For example, upset and sad are simultaneously low positive affect and high negative affect, while happy and content are simultaneously high positive affect and low negative affect.

You will notice that this model does not include all emotions. Some, such as surprise, do not fit well because they are not as clearly positive or negative. Also, keep in mind that emotions cannot be neutral. Being neutral is being nonemotional.¹⁰ As described later in the chapter, people differ in how much they experience PA and NA. Some (we might call them *affectively intense*) may strongly experience quite a bit of high positive and high negative affect in a matter of days or weeks.¹¹ Others might experience little of either. And still, some people may tend to experience one much more predominately than the other.¹²

The Basic Emotions

You might be wondering, how many emotions are there? There are dozens—including anger, contempt, enthusiasm, envy, fear, frustration, disappointment, embarrassment, disgust, happiness, hate, hope, jealousy, joy, love, pride, surprise, and sadness. Numerous researchers have tried to limit them to a fundamental set.¹³ Other scholars argue that by thinking in terms of “basic” emotions, we lose sight of the bigger picture because emotions can mean different things in different contexts and may vary across cultures.¹⁴ It is unlikely that psychologists or philosophers will ever completely agree on a set of basic emotions or even on whether there is such a thing. Still, many researchers agree on six universal emotions—anger, fear, sadness, happiness, disgust, and surprise.¹⁵ If you have ever held a job before, you can probably think of times when you have experienced these emotions in the workplace. For example, you might experience negative affect after a lousy performance review from your supervisor at the department store where you work. You might be angry with your boss, fearful of being terminated, or surprised that the supervisor gave you such a poor evaluation.

Psychologists have tried to identify basic emotions by studying how we express them. Facial expressions have proved difficult to interpret.¹⁶ One problem is that some emotions are too complex to be easily represented on our faces. Second, although people can, for the most part, recognize emotions across cultures at better-than-chance levels, this accuracy is worse for cultural groups with less exposure to one another.¹⁷ Employees can also vocally express their emotions, and artificial intelligence (AI) is advancing research in this area. For example, one machine learning (see introductory chapter) study of speeches from one hundred professional actors across various English-speaking countries found that people are better at recognizing actors' emotions from the same country, suggesting that there are dialect differences in verbally expressing emotions.¹⁸ Differentiating emotions across cultures is quite important in this era of globalization; you may find yourself communicating with people from radically different cultures. Understanding the nuances in how they express emotion can be very helpful. Studying how emotions are displayed, educating yourself on culture-specific emotions, and paying attention to cues when interacting with people from other cultures can help you become a better cross-cultural communicator.¹⁹

Moral Emotions

Some emotions are closely tied to our interpretations of the events that evoke them. One area in which researchers have been furthering this idea is through the study of **moral emotions**, that is, emotions that have moral implications because of our instant judgment of the situation that evokes them.²⁰

Say you watched a video of a coworker making a sexist or racist slur. You might feel disgusted because it offends your sense of right and wrong. You might feel a variety of emotions based on your moral judgment of the situation.²¹ Other examples of moral emotions include sympathy for others' suffering, guilt about our immoral behavior, anger about injustice done to others, and contempt for those who behave unethically. Therefore, we need to be aware of the moral aspects of situations that trigger our emotions and make certain we understand the context before we act, especially in the workplace.²²

Research indicates that our responses to moral emotions differ from our responses to other emotions.²³ When we feel moral anger, we may be more likely to confront the situation that causes it than when we just feel angry. For instance, emergency room doctors and hospital specialists who deal with crises daily found that observing others' suffering led them to experience sympathetic moral emotions and advocate for the patient.²⁴ In contrast, other doctors' unethical behaviors led fellow doctors to become angry and sanction them. However, we cannot assume that our emotional reactions to events will be the same as someone else's. Children develop moral emotions during childhood as they learn moral norms and standards, so moral emotions depend on the situation and normative context more so than other emotions. Because morality differs from one culture to the next, so do moral emotions.

People previously believed that most ethical decision making relied on thinking and cognition. Research on moral emotions increasingly questions this perspective. Numerous studies suggest that ethical decisions are primarily based on feelings rather than on thoughts, even though we tend to see moral issues as logical and reasonable, not as emotional.²⁵ To some degree, our beliefs are shaped by the groups to which we belong, which influence our perceptions of ethics in certain situations. Unfortunately, these shared perceptions may lead us to justify purely emotional reactions as rationally "ethical" just because we share them with others.²⁶ We also tend to judge (and punish) outgroup members (anyone who is not in our group) more harshly for moral transgressions than

moral emotions Emotions that have moral implications because of our instant judgment of the situation that evokes them.

ingroup members, even when we are trying to be objective (see the chapter on diversity).²⁷ Also, we tend to glorify ingroup members (anyone who is part of our group), exercising more leniency when judging their misdeeds, often leading to an ethics double standard.²⁸

You can think about this research to see how moral emotions operate in your own life. Consider a time when you have done something that hurt someone else. Did you feel angry or upset with yourself? Or think about a time when you have seen someone else treated unfairly. Did you feel contempt for the person acting unfairly, or did you engage in a cool, rational calculation of the situation's fairness? Most people who think about these situations have some sense of an emotional stirring that might prompt them to engage in ethical actions like donating money to help others, apologizing and attempting to make amends, or intervening on behalf of those who have been mistreated. In sum, we can conclude that behaving ethically at least partially involves making decisions based on emotions and feelings.

Emotions can be fleeting, but moods can endure, and for quite a while. To understand the impact of emotions and moods in organizations, we next classify the many distinct emotions into broader mood categories.

Experiencing Moods and Emotions

As if it were not complex enough to consider the many distinct emotions a person might experience, the reality is that we all experience moods differently as well. For most people, positive moods are somewhat more common than negative moods. Indeed, research finds nearly universal evidence for a **positivity offset**, meaning that at zero input (when nothing in particular is going on), most individuals experience a mildly positive mood.²⁹ The positivity offset appears for employees in a wide range of job settings. For example, one study of customer service representatives in a British call center revealed that people reported experiencing positive moods 58 percent of the time despite the stressful environment.³⁰ Furthermore, negative emotions tend to lead to negative moods. Perhaps this happens because people think about events that created strong negative emotions five times as long as events that created strong positive ones.³¹

Does the degree to which people experience positive and negative emotions vary across cultures? Yes (see the OB Poll). The reason is not that people of various cultures are inherently different. People in most cultures appear to experience many positive and negative emotions similarly, and people interpret them in much the same way worldwide.³² We all view negative emotions such as hate, terror, and rage as dangerous and destructive. We desire positive emotions such as joy, love, and happiness. However, an individual's experience of emotions appears to be culturally shaped.³³

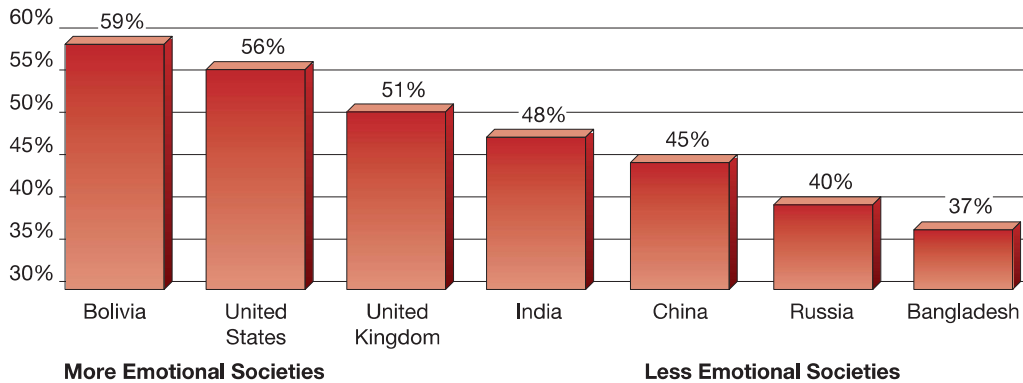
Some cultures value certain emotions more than others, which leads individuals to change their perspective on experiencing these emotions.³⁴ For instance, many cultures, such as Mexico and Brazil, emphasize positive emotions and expressions.³⁵ However, some cultures, such as Japan and Russia, embrace negative emotions as useful and constructive. Interestingly, negative emotions are less detrimental to the health of those of Eastern (negative emotion valuing) as opposed to Western cultures.³⁶ In support, research suggests valuing negative affect often allows people to accept present circumstances and cope, reducing the adverse effects on physical and psychological health and decision making.³⁷ Negative affect may also allow managers to think more critically and fairly.³⁸ However, differences in what is considered *ideal affect* across cultures can have significant implications for workplace diversity. For instance, a series of studies comparing European Americans and Hong Kong Chinese found that European Americans conveyed more PA emotions in their job applications

positivity offset The tendency of most individuals to experience a mildly positive mood at zero input (when nothing in particular is going on).

OB POLL

Emotional States

Percentage of people who reported experiencing emotions on a daily basis*



*Respondents in 148 countries worldwide during 2014 were asked whether they experienced five positive (well-rested, treated with respect, enjoyment, smiling and laughing, learning or doing something interesting) and five negative emotions (anger, stress, sadness, physical pain, worry) daily. Select countries are represented in this figure.

Source: Based on J. Clifton, "Latin Americans Lead World in Emotions," Gallup (August 27, 2015), <http://www.gallup.com/poll/184631/latin-americans-lead-world-emotions.aspx>

and remote interviews than Hong Kong Chinese.³⁹ Furthermore, European American hiring managers rated their ideal applicant as displaying more PA emotions and were more likely to hire applicants who displayed these emotions for internships.⁴⁰

Now that we have identified the basic emotions, the basic moods, and our experience of them, let's explore the function of emotions and moods, particularly in the workplace.

The Function of Emotions

In some ways, emotions are a mystery. What function do they serve? As we will discuss, a large number of reviews suggest that positive employee emotions tend to enhance job attitudes, job engagement, job performance, and organizational citizenship behavior (OCB); decrease withdrawal and counterproductive work behaviors (CWBs); and lead employees to experience more success than their unhappy counterparts.⁴¹ Better yet, individuals who tend to experience positive affect consistently as part of their personalities (see the chapter on personality and individual differences) tend to enjoy these positive outcomes long-term.⁴²

Do Emotions Make Us Irrational? How often have you heard someone say, "Oh, you're just being emotional"? You might have been offended. Observations like this suggest that rationality and emotion are in conflict and that by exhibiting emotion, you are acting irrationally. The perceived association between the two is so strong that some researchers argue that displaying emotions such as sadness to the point of crying is so toxic to a career that we should leave the room rather than allow others to witness it.⁴³ This perspective suggests that the demonstration or even experience of emotions can make us seem weak, brittle, or irrational. However, our emotions can make our thinking *more* rational. Why? Because our emotions provide essential information about how we understand

the world around us and help guide our behaviors. For instance, individuals in a negative mood may be better able to discern truthful from inaccurate information than are people in a happy mood.⁴⁴ Furthermore, cold rationality does not acknowledge that in the world around us people are, by nature, emotional. We would do best to recognize and understand our own emotions (and others') and use this information in our interactions with others.

When we can identify the sources of emotions and moods, we can better predict behavior and manage our interactions with people more effectively. Let's explore that topic next.

Sources of Emotions and Moods

4-2 Identify the sources of emotions and moods.

It's 8:15 a.m. on Monday, and you are so incredibly excited to tell your coworker, Jordan, the good news about the shiny Pokémon you caught in Pokémon Go. You rush over, but Jordan immediately stops you and says, "Don't even talk to me until I've had my coffee." Defeated, you walk back to your station and continue your opening activities. You wonder where this bad mood originated and begin to feel angry toward your coworker. You mutter under your breath, "I won't trade the extra shiny Pokémon I caught with Jordan. We will see who's upset then!" We have all, no doubt, been in a similar situation before. Negative emotions and moods are often unavoidable and can certainly impact our work. Jordan hurt your feelings, harming the floor team's functioning that day; now you may be preoccupied with what Jordan said and miss one of your opening tasks. We are often left wondering where these emotions and moods originated. Was it really the lack of coffee? Maybe something else was going on. Here we discuss some of the primary influences on emotions and moods.

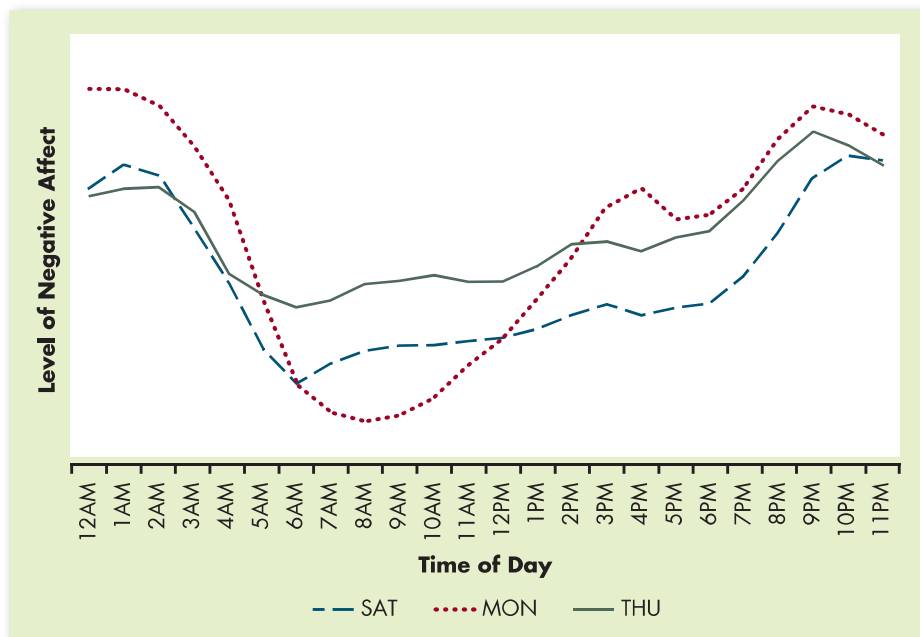
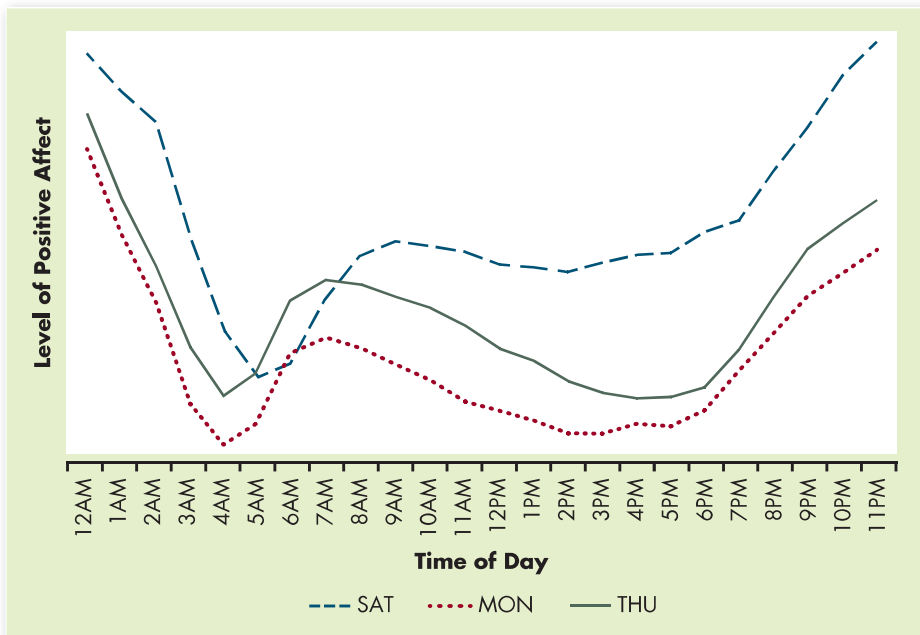
Personality

Affect has a personality trait component, meaning that some people have built-in tendencies to experience certain moods and emotions more frequently than others. Is Jordan frequently prone to experiencing negative emotions? It could be that Jordan's reaction is a reflection of personality. People also experience the same emotions with different intensities; the degree to which they experience them is called their **affect intensity**.⁴⁵ Affectively intense people experience both positive and negative emotions more deeply: When they are sad, they are really sad, and when they are happy, they are really happy. Both the tendency to experience positive and negative emotions and the intensity at which we feel them affect several factors at work, such as our typical moods, job satisfaction, and engagement at work (see the chapter on attitudes and job satisfaction).⁴⁶ For example, one review of more than one hundred studies suggests that the tendency to experience positive emotions and moods is the strongest predictor of whether an employee is engaged.⁴⁷

affect intensity Individual differences in the strength with which individuals experience their emotions.

Time of Day

Maybe it was just too early for Jordan to interact with coworkers. Indeed, research does show that moods vary by the time of day. Furthermore, most of us follow the same pattern. On a typical weekday, levels of positive affect tend to rise in the morning after sunrise, peaking in the late morning (ten o'clock to noon) and then slowly decline until early evening (around six o'clock). Then positive affect switches direction and increases until midnight. Afterward, the trajectory switches direction again and declines until sunrise.⁴⁸ As for negative affect, most research suggests it fluctuates less than positive affect.⁴⁹ However, the general trend is for it to increase over the day, so it is lowest early in the morning and highest late in the evening.⁵⁰ A fascinating study assessed the effect of time

Exhibit 4-3**Time of Day Effects on U.S. Adults' Affect From Tweets**

Note: Based on analysis of U.S. tweets (i.e., Twitter postings) and coding of words that represent positive (e.g., delight, enthusiasm) and negative (e.g., fear, guilt) affect. Lines represent the percentage of total words that convey these emotions.

Sources: Based on S. A. Golder and M. W. Macy, "Diurnal and Seasonal Mood Vary With Work, Sleep, and Daylength Across Diverse Cultures," *Science* 333 (2011): 1878–81; A. Elejalde-Ruiz, "Seize the Day," *Chicago Tribune*, September 5, 2012, downloaded June 20, 2013, from <http://articles.chicagotribune.com/>

of day on affect by analyzing millions of tweets (i.e., Twitter messages) worldwide.⁵¹ The researchers captured words connoting positive affect (e.g., happy, enthused, excited) and negative (e.g., sad, angry, anxious) affect. You can see the trends they observed in the positive affect part of Exhibit 4-3.

You may wonder what happens for people who work the third shift at night. When our internal circadian process is out of line with our waking hours, our moods and well-being are likely to be negatively affected. However, researchers studying how the body's inner clock can be adjusted have found that governing our exposure to light may allow us to shift our circadian rhythms.⁵² Thus, by manipulating light and darkness, someone who is awake at night might have a similar mood cycle to someone who sleeps at night.

Day of the Week

Was this just a case of the “Mondays” for Jordan? In most cultures, Mondays can be . . . “problematic” for employees—for example, as shown in Exhibit 4-4, U.S. adults tend to experience their highest positive affect on Friday, Saturday, and Sunday and their lowest on Monday.⁵³ This tends to be true in several other cultures. This is not the case in all cultures, however. In Japan, positive affect is higher on Monday than on either Friday or Saturday.⁵⁴

As for negative affect, Monday is the highest negative-affect day across most cultures.⁵⁵ However, in some countries, negative affect is lower on Friday and Saturday than on Sunday. It may be that while Sunday is enjoyable as a day off (and thus we have higher positive affect), people also get a bit stressed about the week ahead (which is why negative affect is higher).

Weather

Maybe Jordan was feeling a little . . . “under the weather.” Many people believe that their mood is tied to the weather, and indeed, there are many self-proclaimed “rain haters” and “summer lovers.”⁵⁶ However, an extensive body of evidence suggests weather has little effect on mood, at least for most people.⁵⁷ **Illusory correlation**, which occurs when we associate two events that, in reality, have no connection, explains why people tend to *think* weather influences them. For example, employees may be more productive on bad weather days, a study in Japan and the United States demonstrated, but not because of mood. Instead, the worse weather removed some work distractions.⁵⁸

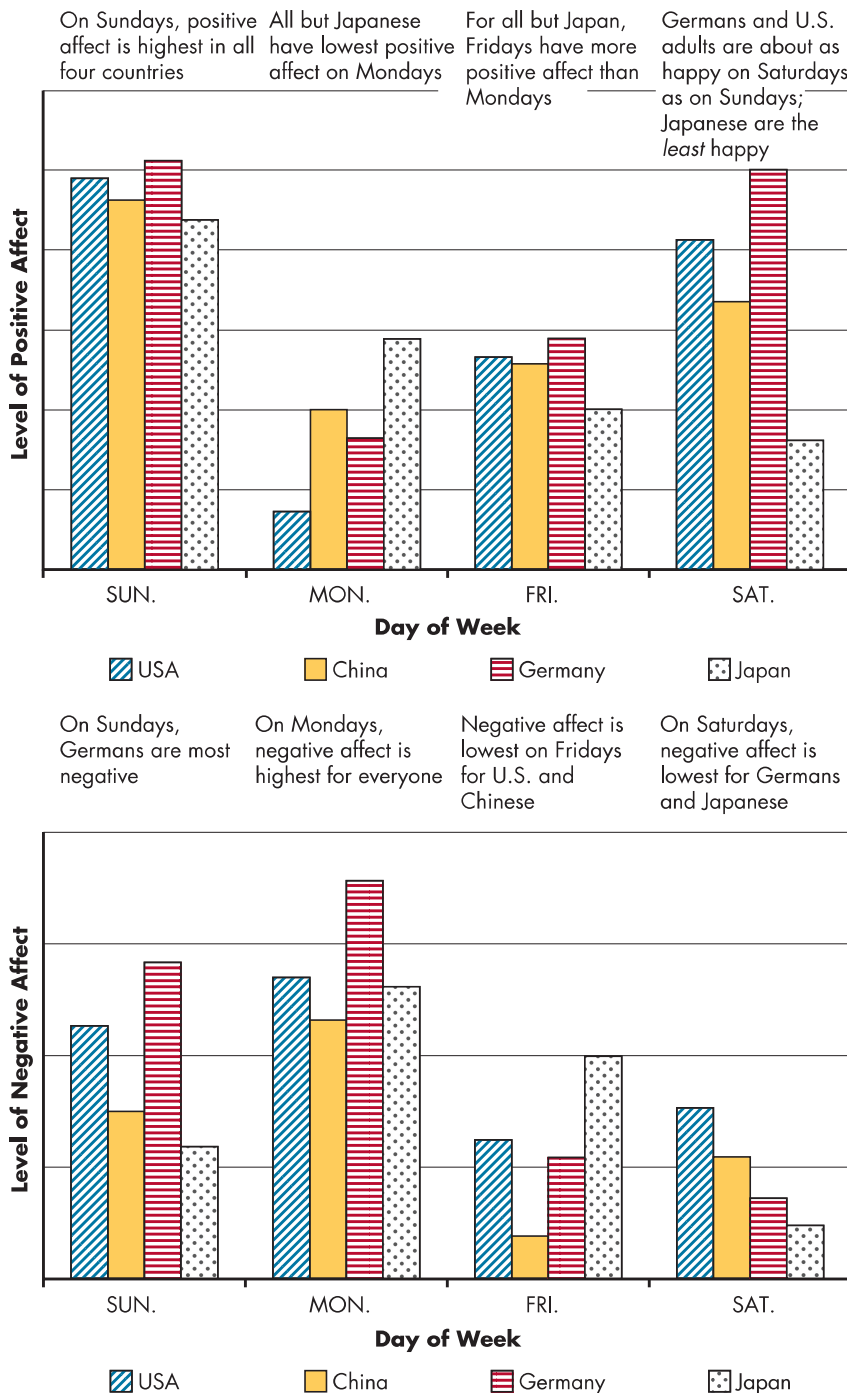
illusory correlation The tendency of people to associate two events when in reality there is no connection.

Stress

Maybe Jordan was anxious about a worrisome meeting with the manager later that afternoon. As you might imagine, stressful events at work (a nasty e-mail, impending deadline, loss of a big sale, reprimand from the boss, etc.) negatively affect our emotions and moods (which we discuss in more detail in the chapter on organizational health and stress). As the authors of one study note, “A constant diet of even low-level stressful events has the potential to cause workers to experience gradually increasing levels of strain over time.”⁵⁹ Mounting levels of stress can worsen our moods as we experience more negative emotions. Although sometimes we thrive on it,⁶⁰ most of us find stress usually takes a toll on our mood. In fact, when situations are overly emotionally charged and stressful, we have a natural response to disengage, to literally look away.⁶¹

Social Interactions

Just as Jordan may have had a negative interaction with the supervisor early in the day, so too were you affected by your interaction with Jordan. Indeed the interactions we have with other people can affect our emotions and moods. These negative experiences can also, by consequence, affect our relationships with others, leading to strengthened or dissolving bonds between people.⁶² As an example, negative interactions at work not only can affect your emotions at work, they are so powerful that these emotions can “spill over” and affect your relationships with family members.⁶³ Social interactions also do not solely result

Exhibit 4-4**Day-of-Week Mood Effects Across Four Cultures**

Source: Based on S. A. Golder and M. W. Macy, "Diurnal and Seasonal Mood Vary With Work, Sleep, and Daylength Across Diverse Cultures," *Science* 333 (2011): 1878–81; A. Elejalde-Ruiz, "Seize the Day," *Chicago Tribune*, September 5, 2012, downloaded June 20, 2013, from <http://articles.chicagotribune.com/>

in purely positive or negative emotions. For instance, in lukewarm, tepid interactions with people, we may be bored and less motivated to make or maintain a relationship. On the other hand, interactions that take us on "an emotional roller coaster" (e.g., experience both positive and negative social interactions frequently) can lead us to feel bittersweet or conflicted about that person.⁶⁴

Sleep

Maybe Jordan was extremely tired that morning due to a lack of sleep (and, hence, the need for coffee). Apparently, the world could use more sleep, with roughly 62 percent of adults from twelve countries reporting in 2019 that they do not sleep well or long enough.⁶⁵ Adults report sleeping less than adults did a generation ago.⁶⁶ Data mined from millions of users of the “Sleep Cycle” app suggest that on average, sleep length and quality have diminished over the years.⁶⁷

Sleep quality affects moods and decision making, and increased fatigue puts workers at risk of disease, injury, and depression.⁶⁸ Poor or reduced sleep also leads to emotional changes, makes it difficult to control emotions, and can impair job satisfaction.⁶⁹ On the positive side, increased regular sleep can reduce the negative effects of fatigue and stress on employees’ emotions.⁷⁰ Furthermore, University of California–San Diego researchers calculated that, for employees who do not sleep enough, “a one-hour increase in long-run average sleep increases wages by 16 percent, equivalent to more than a year of schooling.”⁷¹

Exercise

To deal with the negative emotions surrounding your interaction with Jordan, have you considered exercising after work (maybe play some more Pokémon Go)? Perhaps you have heard that people should exercise to improve their mood. Does “sweat therapy” really work? It appears so. Research consistently shows that exercise enhances people’s positive moods and reduces perceptions of fatigue.⁷² Exercise can also help protect against persistent negative moods and improve the ability to recover from negative experiences.⁷³

Gender Identity

You may think that Jordan’s behavior may be attributable to gender differences in emotions. Indeed, many people may stereotypically believe women are more emotional than men (see the chapter on diversity). Although several reviews have found differences in emotion display across genders that tend to increase with age,⁷⁴ these tend to be trivial or small and likely reflect differences in upbringing and stereotypes or even the way emotions are measured rather than actual differences.⁷⁵

Unfortunately, these stereotypical perceptions of women as “emotional” and men as “angry” persist in the workplace despite little evidence that they are true. For example, a Denver police commander filed a civil rights complaint

Staples believes that exercise increases positive moods and results in happier, healthier, and more productive employees. At company headquarters, the office supply retailer offers employees onsite strength training and cardiovascular conditioning classes during their lunch hour, including a truck push (shown here), military crawls, and other boot-camp-type activities.

Source: Pat Greenhouse/*Boston Globe*/Getty Images



against the city for gender discrimination, noting that the chief told her she was “emotional” and “immature,” denying her a promotion to deputy chief.⁷⁶ People also tend to make attributions about women’s personalities in ways that might be based on stereotypes of typical emotional reactions. One study showed that when viewing pictures of faces, participants interpreted the women’s emotional expressions as being dispositional (related to personality), whereas the men’s expressions were interpreted as situational.⁷⁷ For example, a picture of a sad woman led observers to believe she had an emotional personality, whereas a picture of sadness in a man was more likely to be attributed to having a bad day.

Let us put together what we have learned about emotions and moods with workplace coping strategies, beginning with emotional labor.

Emotional Labor

If you have ever had a job in retail or in sales or waited on tables in a restaurant, you know the importance of projecting a friendly demeanor and smiling. Even though there were days when you did not feel cheerful, you knew management expected you to be upbeat when dealing with customers, so you either tried to become upbeat and cheerful or otherwise faked it.

When you work, you expend physical and mental labor (or energy) by putting your body and mind, respectively, into your job. But jobs also require **emotional labor**, an employee’s expression of organizationally desired emotions during interpersonal transactions at work.⁷⁸ Emotional labor is a key component of effective job performance.⁷⁹ We expect flight attendants to be cheerful, funeral directors to be sad, and doctors to be emotionally neutral.

4-3 Show the impact that emotional labor has on employees.

emotional labor An employee’s organizationally desired emotions during interpersonal transactions at work.

Controlling Emotional Displays

The way we experience an emotion is obviously not always the same as the way we show it. To analyze emotional labor, we divide emotions into *felt* or *displayed* emotions.⁸⁰ **Felt emotions** are our actual emotions.⁸¹ In contrast, **displayed emotions** are those the organization requires workers to show and considers appropriate in each job. For instance, research suggests that in U.S. workplaces, it is expected that employees should typically display positive emotions like happiness and excitement and suppress negative emotions like fear, anger, disgust, and contempt.⁸²

Effective managers have learned to look serious when they give an employee a negative performance evaluation and to look calm when they are berated by their bosses because the organization expects these displays. Conversely, effective employees have learned to earn their managers’ favor (and perhaps pay raises and promotions) by enthusiastically agreeing with their supervisors.⁸³ Of course, there are no display rules for many workplace situations. Does your employer dictate what emotions you display when you are, say, heading out for lunch? Probably not. Many workplaces have explicit display rules, but usually only for interactions that matter, particularly between employees and customers. Regarding employee and customer interactions, you might expect that the more an employer dictates salespeople’s emotional displays, the higher the sales. Employees under very high or very low display rules do not perform as well in sales situations as employees who have moderate display rules and a high degree of discretion in their roles.⁸⁴ Furthermore, informal display rules can also be biased. For instance, research uncovered a stereotype that Black grocery store workers were perceived as less warm than White workers, leading Black grocery store workers to engage in more emotional labor (by displaying more positive emotions) than White workers.⁸⁵ In other words, Black workers were held to a higher customer service standard because of the stereotype.

felt emotions An individual’s actual emotions.

displayed emotions Emotions that are organizationally required and considered appropriate in a given job.

surface acting Hiding one's feelings and forgoing emotional expressions in response to display rules.

deep acting Trying to modify one's true feelings based on display rules.

emotional dissonance Inconsistencies between the emotions people feel and the emotions they project.

Displaying fake emotions requires us to suppress real ones. **Surface acting** is hiding feelings and emotional expressions in response to display rules. A worker who smiles at a customer even when they do not feel like it is surface acting. **Deep acting** is trying to modify our true feelings based on display rules. Surface acting deals with *displayed* emotions, and deep acting deals with *felt* emotions. The COVID-19 context and proliferation of virtual/remote work have made the nature of surface and deep acting even more complex. In other words, with fewer face-to-face interactions, can people even tell whether emotions are authentic? One study in the COVID-19 era found that e-mail can be better for “masking” emotional leakage, although it is a double-edged sword because recipients view “richer” forms of communication like Zoom as conveying the “authenticity” of emotions better. On the other hand, for surface actors, a middle ground is better (e.g., telephone).⁸⁶

Displaying emotions we do not really feel can be exhausting because they take effort to display and can make us feel inauthentic.⁸⁷ Surface acting is associated with increased stress and decreased job satisfaction.⁸⁸ Daily surface acting can also lead to emotional exhaustion at home, work–family conflict, absenteeism, and insomnia.⁸⁹ On the other hand, deep acting has a positive relationship with job satisfaction (especially when the work is challenging), job performance, and even better customer treatment and tips.⁹⁰

The disparity between employees having to project one emotion *while feeling another* is called **emotional dissonance**. Bottled-up feelings of frustration, anger, and resentment can lead to emotional exhaustion. Long-term emotional dissonance is a predictor for job burnout, declines in job performance, lower job satisfaction, and even more nefarious effects like alcohol abuse and lashing out at coworkers.⁹¹

Myth or Science?

All Employees Experience Emotional Labor in the Same Way

All employees experience emotional labor in some way. However, there is substantial variation in the degree to which employees experience it and its consequences. Research reveals that, in general, the experience of emotional labor is more taxing for introverts compared with extroverts. Surface acting (hiding feelings and emotional expressions) is also more strongly related to emotional exhaustion and negative affect for introverts than extroverts. On the other hand, deep acting (trying to modify true feelings) was more strongly related to extroverts' negative affect. These findings demonstrate that deep acting's negative and positive emotional effects both impact extroverts.

There are also important implications for individuals and organizations. Extroverts likely perform well in sales

positions not only because they are more sociable but also because of their capacity to cope with the emotional demands typical in service jobs. Even though some employees may be well equipped to handle emotional labor's demands, surface acting still tends to result in greater emotional exhaustion and reduced job satisfaction. Organizations cannot regulate their employees' emotions, but they can minimize the disconnection between expected and felt emotions. One strategy could be teaching employees to frame customer demands as challenges rather than threats.

Personality is not the only factor that influences how employees experience emotional labor. For instance, one study found that Black service providers who did not engage in emotional

labor (e.g., deep acting) were perceived as less warm than White service providers. In this study, Black service providers had to exert more emotional effort to be viewed favorably by customers, which researchers attribute to racial stereotypes. Also, prior research has shown that supervisors rated Black employees lower on interpersonal warmth and job performance than White employees. Although Black employees might engage in additional emotional labor practices to match others' service performance, the inequity and additional effort are demanding and harmful to one's sense of self and well-being. More attention needs to be directed toward developing strategies that can reduce the barriers Black employees may face, particularly in the service industry.⁹²

Emotionally intelligent employees (as discussed in a later section)⁹³ as well as those who have a high capacity for self-control, who sleep well every night, who have strong relationships with their customers or clients, and who are empowered to give help to others at work tend to be buffered to some degree from the negative side effects of emotional dissonance.⁹⁴ However, employees who fear isolation and strongly desire to please others (and belong to the group) are more likely to experience the negative effects of emotional dissonance.⁹⁵ In general, although there are individual differences that affect how employees manage emotional labor, research suggests that employees, leaders, and managers can be trained to regulate their emotional displays when appropriate.⁹⁶

Affective events theory, discussed in the next section, fits a job's emotional labor requirements into a construct with implications for work events, emotional reactions, job satisfaction, and job performance.

Affective Events Theory

We have seen that emotions and moods are an important part of our personal and work lives. But how do they influence our job performance and satisfaction? **Affective events theory (AET)** proposes that employees react emotionally to things that happen to them at work, and these reactions influence their job performance and satisfaction.⁹⁷ For example, Lisamarie, a benefits administrator in North Carolina, began the in vitro fertilization (IVF) process after she was unable to conceive a child for six years and halfway through found out her employer was dropping the benefit—she was “gutted” and “lost,” “cried for a week,” and undoubtedly did not feel satisfied with her job following such a blow.⁹⁸

Work events trigger positive or negative emotional reactions, to which employees' personalities and moods predispose them to respond with greater or lesser intensity.⁹⁹ However, we experience some events more often than others, so does this have an effect on the types of affective reactions we experience at work? Some research supports the idea that it does, given that interpersonal mistreatment by customers of part-time workers accounted for nearly 50 percent of negative affective work events.¹⁰⁰

Further, given the shift toward remote work in the modern era, researchers have turned their sights toward what affective events look like for remote workers. For remote workers, a positive affective event might be a quick and productive Zoom meeting with colleagues, whereas a negative affective event might be a terrible connection (and a conspicuous high-pitched screech that no one can diagnose) making it difficult to get anything done.¹⁰¹

In sum, AET offers two important messages.¹⁰² First, emotions provide valuable insights into how workplace events influence employee performance and satisfaction. Second, employees and managers should not ignore emotions or the events that cause them, even when they appear minor, because they accumulate. EI is another framework that helps us understand the impact of emotions on job performance, so we will look at that topic next.

Emotional Intelligence

As the CEO of an international talent company, Terrie Upshur-Lupberger was at a career pinnacle. So why was she resentful and unhappy? A close friend observed, “Terrie, you were out on the skinny branch—you know, the one that breaks easily in a strong wind. You were so busy and overwhelmed and out of

4-4 Describe affective events theory.

affective events theory (AET) A model suggesting that workplace events cause emotional reactions on the part of employees, which then influence workplace attitudes and behaviors.

4-5 Describe emotional intelligence.

touch with your own values, cares, and guiding beliefs that you failed to pay attention to the branch that was about to break.”¹⁰³ According to Upshur-Lupberger, she had failed to notice that her moods constantly swung toward frustration and exhaustion. Her job satisfaction, productivity, and relationships suffered. Worse, she was too busy to realize the deficiencies until she was completely depleted. She said, “I learned that, as a leader, you either pay attention to and manage the moods (including your own) in the organization, or... you ignore them and pay the price.”¹⁰⁴ Upshur-Lupberger learned the value of emotional intelligence (EI).

Employers value EI. In one CareerBuilder survey of more than 2,500 hiring managers and HR professionals, 59 percent said they would not hire someone with high cognitive ability (e.g., IQ; see the chapter on personality and individual differences) but low EI, and 75 percent said they would be more likely to promote a high EI candidate over one with high IQ.¹⁰⁵ In another study that tracked college students from graduation to more than ten years after entering the workforce, EI predicted how high their salary was ten years later as well as whether the alumni had a mentor.¹⁰⁶

Emotional intelligence (EI) is a person’s ability to (1) perceive emotions in oneself and others, (2) understand the meaning of these emotions, and (3) regulate one’s own emotions accordingly, as shown in Exhibit 4-5.¹⁰⁷ When asked why they value EI over cognitive ability, the managers in the Career Builder study noted that they are more in tune with their emotions, so they can stay calm under pressure, resolve conflict more effectively, be empathetic with coworkers and team members, and effectively regulate their emotions.¹⁰⁸

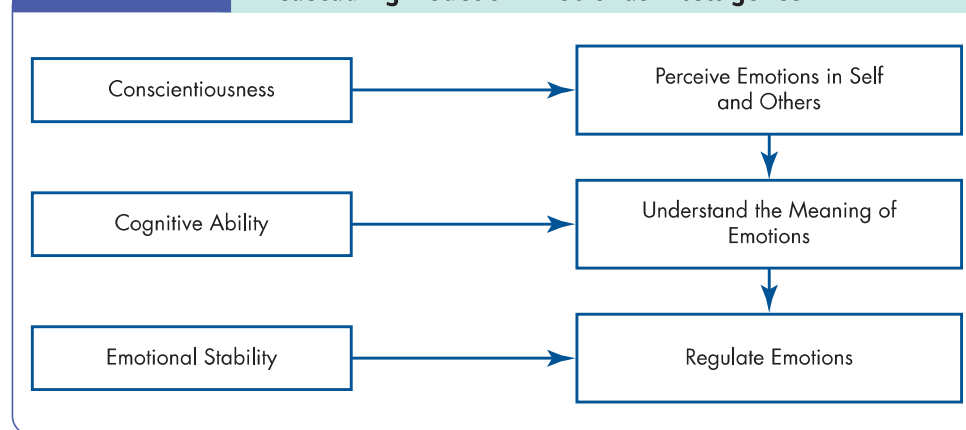
Several studies suggest that EI plays an important role in predicting job attitudes and facilitating academic and job performance, although the survey items are often strikingly similar to other items from personality, intelligence, and self-perception tests.¹⁰⁹ Other reviews suggest that EI is related to improving teamwork effectiveness, organizational citizenship behaviors (OCBs) (see introductory chapter), and career decision making (e.g., managing employment gaps) as well as reducing CWBs (see the chapter on job attitudes).¹¹⁰ South Korean managers with high EI tend to have better sales figures than those with low EI because they were able to create more cohesive stores and improved sales-directed behavior.¹¹¹

For a leadership perspective, one research study examined eleven U.S. presidents—from Franklin Roosevelt to Bill Clinton—and evaluated them on

emotional intelligence (EI) The ability to detect and to manage emotional cues and information.

Exhibit 4-5

A Cascading Model of Emotional Intelligence



Source: Based on D. L. Joseph and D. A. Newman, “Emotional Intelligence: An Integrative Meta-Analysis and Cascading Model,” *Journal of Applied Psychology* 95, no. 1 (2010): 54–78.

six qualities: communication, organization, political skill, vision, cognitive style, and EI. The key quality that differentiated the successful (such as Roosevelt, Kennedy, and Reagan) from the unsuccessful (such as Johnson, Carter, and Nixon) was EI.¹¹² Furthermore, studies of popularity suggest that it is EI, not narcissism, that predicts long-term popularity.¹¹³ As such, leaders and employees alike who are high on EI tend to be more popular and successful because they are able to understand and manage their own and others' emotions.¹¹⁴

However, it appears as if there are limits to the degree to which EI can be helpful in the workplace. For example, one study of Dutch administrative assistants suggests that EI that is focused on the self (e.g., self-understanding) decreases the experience of stress, but with physiological costs, while other-focused EI (e.g., accurately perceiving emotions in others) only weakly explained task performance.¹¹⁵ This suggests that EI may be costly and not as effective as we think, especially in emotionally demanding contexts. Furthermore, some research suggests that EI might even be related to how well people can fake tests (because they understand what desirable answers are on tests).¹¹⁶ According to this research, if you use a personality test to screen candidates for a job, those with high EI may be better at faking it.

An Ethical Choice

Should Managers Use Emotional Intelligence (EI) Tests?

As we discussed in this chapter, the concept of EI has raised some debate. One of the decisions for managers is whether to use EI tests in the selection process. Here are some ethical considerations:

- *There is no commonly accepted test.* For instance, researchers have recently used the Mayer–Salovey–Caruso Emotional Intelligence Test (MSCEIT), the Trait Emotional Intelligence Questionnaire, and the Situational Judgment Test of Emotional Intelligence (SJT of EI) in studies. Researchers feel EI tests may need to be culturally specific because emotional displays vary by culture; thus, the interpretation of emotional cues differs. For example, a recent study comparing the EI scores for Indian and North American executives using the Emotional Competence Inventory (ECI-2) test found the results similar but not the same, suggesting the need for modification.
- *Applicants may react negatively to taking an EI test in general or to parts of it.* The face recognition test, for example, may seem culturally biased to some if the subject photos are not diverse. Also, participants who score high on EI tests tend to consider them fair; applicants who score lower may not perceive the tests to be fair and can thus view the hiring organizations unfavorably—even if they score well on other assessments.
- *It remains somewhat unclear what EI tests are actually measuring.* They may reflect personality or intelligence, in which case other measures might be better. Also, some EI tests may predict job performance, but many of these tests include personality constructs and measures of general mental ability.
- *There is not enough research on how EI affects, for instance, CWB.* It may not be prudent to test and select applicants who are rated high on EI when we are not yet certain that everything about EI leads to desired workplace outcomes.
- *There is not enough research on how EI affects, for instance, CWB.* It may not be prudent to test and select applicants who are rated high on EI when we are not yet certain that everything about EI leads to desired workplace outcomes.
- *These concerns suggest that EI tests should be avoided in hiring decisions.* However, because research has indicated that EI does predict job performance to some degree, managers should not be too hasty to dismiss them altogether. Rather, those wishing to use EI in hiring decisions should be aware of these issues to make informed and ethical decisions about not only whom to hire but how.¹¹⁷
- *EL tests may not be predictive of performance for all types of jobs.* In a study of six hundred Romanian participants, results indicated that EI was valid for salespeople, public servants, and CEOs of public hospitals, but these were all roles requiring significant social interaction. EI tests may need to be tailored for each position category or not be used when the position description does not warrant such tests.

Although the field is progressing in its understanding of EI, many questions have not been answered.¹¹⁸ One relates to a better understanding of EI. For example, we need to be precise when we talk about EI—are we referring to EI in general? Or to regulating emotions, understanding emotions, or perceiving emotions specifically? A second question is about the reliability of EI testing and how best to measure EI. Several advancements have been made in this area, for example, by having test-takers recognize emotions from video clips and by having them respond with what they would do in emotionally charged situations.¹¹⁹ A third question is one of the most important for managers in organizations: Can EI be learned? Several reviews of dozens of studies suggest that EI can be trained and developed as a skill—although, paradoxically, the people who need it the most are the ones least likely to actually seek it out!¹²⁰

All questions aside, EI is wildly popular among consulting firms and in the popular press, and it has accumulated some support in the research literature. Love it or hate it, one thing is for sure—EI is here to stay. So might be our next topic, emotion regulation, which is increasingly studied as an independent concept.¹²¹

Emotion Regulation

4-6 Identify strategies for emotion regulation.

emotion regulation The process of identifying and modifying felt emotions.

Have you ever tried to cheer yourself up when you were feeling down or calm yourself when you were feeling angry? If so, you have engaged in **emotion regulation**.¹²² The central idea behind emotion regulation is to identify and modify the emotions you feel. For instance, workers worldwide have had to regulate emotions in the face of the COVID-19 pandemic, with many facing an uncertain labor market as well as changing family responsibilities and work-family conflict.¹²³ Emotion regulation is a strong predictor of task performance for some jobs and for OCB.¹²⁴ Therefore, in our study of OB, we are interested in *when* and *how* emotion regulation is used in the workplace. We begin by identifying which individuals might naturally employ it.

Emotion Regulation Influences and Outcomes

As you might suspect, not everyone is equally good at regulating emotions.¹²⁵ Individuals who are higher in the personality trait of neuroticism (see the chapter on personality and individual differences) have more trouble doing so and often find that their moods are beyond their ability to control. Individuals who have lower levels of self-esteem are also less likely to try to improve their sad moods, perhaps because they are less likely than others to feel they deserve to be in a good mood.¹²⁶ Finally, university seniors who are more focused on mastering the job search process were better able to regulate their emotions and engaged in more job search behaviors as a result.¹²⁷

The workplace environment influences an individual's tendency to employ emotion regulation. In general, diversity in work groups increases the likelihood that you will regulate your emotions. For example, younger employees are likely to regulate their emotions when their work groups include older members.¹²⁸ Racial diversity also has an effect: If diversity is low, the underrepresented employee will engage in emotion regulation, perhaps to “fit in” with the other employees as much as possible.¹²⁹ These findings suggest a beneficial outcome of diversity—it may cause us to regulate our emotions more consciously and effectively.

While regulating your emotions might seem beneficial, research suggests there may be a downside to trying to change the way you feel. Changing your emotions takes effort and, as we noted when discussing emotional labor, this effort can be exhausting. Sometimes attempts to change an emotion actually make the emotion stronger; for example, trying to talk yourself out of being afraid can make you focus more on what scares you, which makes you more

afraid.¹³⁰ From another perspective, research suggests that avoiding negative emotional experiences is less likely to lead to positive moods than does seeking out positive emotional experiences.¹³¹ For example, you are more likely to experience a positive mood if you have a pleasant conversation with a friend than if you avoid an unpleasant conversation with a hostile coworker.

Interestingly, some positions involve more customer incivility and mistreatment directed toward employees than others—positions with higher levels of customer mistreatment (e.g., call center employees) necessitate more employee emotion regulation and, as a result, can lead to higher levels of employee exhaustion.¹³² Do you want to make a customer service employee's life easier? Be nice to them! One study of supermarket checkout operators found that smiling at checkout staff and engaging in short conversations reduces the staff members' emotion regulation needs and as such reduces their emotional exhaustion and improves their performance.¹³³

Emotion Regulation Techniques

Researchers of emotion regulation often study the strategies people employ to change their emotions (for example, as we discussed earlier in the chapter, *deep acting* and *surface acting* are emotion regulation techniques).

One technique of emotion regulation is *emotional suppression*, or suppressing initial emotional responses to situations. This response seems to facilitate practical thinking in the short term but is generally ineffective when compared with expressing ones' emotions.¹³⁴ However, it appears to be helpful only when a strongly negative event would illicit a distressed emotional reaction during a crisis.¹³⁵ For example, a portfolio manager might suppress an emotional reaction to a sudden drop in the value of a stock and can therefore clearly decide how to plan. Suppression used in crisis situations appears to help an individual recover from the event emotionally, while suppression used as an everyday emotion regulation technique can take a toll on mental ability, emotional ability, health, and relationships.¹³⁶ Thus, unless we are truly in a crisis, acknowledging rather than suppressing our emotional responses to situations and reevaluating events after they occur yield the best outcomes.¹³⁷

Cognitive reappraisal, or reframing our outlook on an emotional situation, is one way to regulate emotions effectively.¹³⁸ Cognitive reappraisal ability seems to be the most helpful to individuals in situations where they cannot control the sources of stress.¹³⁹ For example, if you lost your job, reframing it as an opportunity to try the new career you always dreamed about may help you regulate your emotions. One study illustrates the potentially powerful effect of this technique. Israeli participants who were shown anger-inducing information about the Israeli–Palestinian conflict after they were primed to reappraise the situation showed more inclination toward conciliation and less inclination toward aggressive tactics against Palestinians than the control group, not only immediately after the study but up to five months later. This result suggests that cognitive reappraisal may allow people to change their emotional responses, even when the subject matter is as highly emotionally charged as the Israeli–Palestinian conflict.¹⁴⁰ However, cognitive reappraisal can be used for unethical aims—for instance, reappraising the shame and guilt one would anticipate for performing CWBs may lead people to reconsider and actually commit to engaging in unethical CWBs.¹⁴¹ Yet another study found that cognitive reappraisal can actually *lead to* mental fatigue, suggesting that not all of the outcomes of cognitive reappraisal are positive.¹⁴²

Another technique with potential for emotion regulation is *social sharing*, or venting. Research shows that the open expression of emotions can help individuals to regulate their emotions as opposed to keeping emotions “bottled up.” Social sharing can reduce anger reactions when people can talk about the facts of a bad situation, their feelings about the situation, or any positive aspects of the situation.¹⁴³ For example, venting to your coworker after work about the

heated interchange with your manager in the kitchen may help you express your feelings and understand the situation a little better. Caution must be exercised, though, because expressing your frustration affects other people. In fact, whether venting emotions helps the “venter” feel better depends very much upon the listener’s response. If the listener does not respond (many refuse to respond to venting), the venter feels worse. If the listener responds with expressions of support or validation, the venter feels better. Therefore, if we are going to vent to a coworker, we need to choose someone who will respond sympathetically. Venting to the perceived offender rarely improves things and can result in heightening the negative emotions.¹⁴⁴

While emotion regulation techniques can help us cope with difficult workplace situations, research indicates that the effect varies. For example, one study of employees working for abusive supervisors reported emotional exhaustion and work-withdrawal tendencies but to different degrees based on the emotion regulation strategies they employed. Employees who used suppression techniques suffered greater emotional exhaustion and work withdrawal than employees who used cognitive reappraisal. This suggests that more research on the application of techniques needs to be done to help employees increase their coping skills.¹⁴⁵

Ethics of Emotion Regulation

Emotion regulation has important ethical implications. On one end of the continuum, some people might argue or perceive that controlling your emotions is unethical because it requires a degree of acting.¹⁴⁶ On the other end, people might argue that all emotions should be controlled so you can take a dispassionate perspective. Both arguments—and all arguments in between—have ethical pros and cons that you will have to decide for yourself. Consider the reasons for emotion regulation and the outcomes. Are you regulating your emotions so you do not react inappropriately, or are you regulating your emotions so no one knows what you are thinking? Consider this: You may be able to “fake it ‘til you make it.” Recent research has found that acting like you are in a good mood might *put* you in a good mood. In one study, a group of participants was asked to hold only an efficient conversation with a barista serving them at Starbucks, while another group was asked to act happy. The happy actors reported later that they were in much better moods.¹⁴⁷

The key is to be adaptive: Try to be aware of your emotions and use the regulation techniques best suited for the situation.¹⁴⁸ Now that we have studied the role of emotions and moods in OB, let’s consider the opportunities for more specific applications that our understanding provides.

OB Applications of Emotions and Moods

4-7 Apply concepts about emotions and moods to specific OB issues.

Our understanding of emotions and moods can affect many aspects of OB, including the selection process, decision making, creativity, motivation, leadership, negotiation, customer service, job attitudes, deviant workplace behavior, and safety. Let’s think through each of these.

The Selection Process

One implication from the evidence on EI is that employers should consider it a factor in hiring employees, especially for jobs that demand a high degree of social interaction. In fact, more employers *are* starting to use EI measures to hire people. For example, a study of U.S. Air Force recruiters showed that top-performing recruiters exhibited high levels of EI. Using these findings, the Air Force revamped its selection criteria. A follow-up investigation found hires who had high EI scores were 2.6 times more

successful than those who did not.¹⁴⁹ A second implication is that applicant emotions are sometimes, knowingly or not, used in selection decisions. As we mentioned earlier, research demonstrates that the emotional displays of applicants are often used in hiring decisions.¹⁵⁰ Selecting positive team members can contribute toward a positive work environment because positive moods from these leaders can transmit from team member to team member. One study of 130 leaders and their followers found that leaders who are charismatic transfer their positive emotions to their followers through a contagion effect.¹⁵¹ It makes sense, then, to choose team members predisposed to positive moods. Finally, the affect of job seekers matters as well—when on the hunt for a new job, one is often assailed with setbacks, distressing affective events, and threats to one's competence. In these cases, it is best to have compassion toward yourself, as research shows that this can buffer the negative emotions experienced during job search.¹⁵²

Decision Making

Moods and emotions have effects on decision making that employees and managers should understand. Positive emotions and moods seem to help people make sound decisions. Positive emotions also enhance problem-solving skills, so positive people find better solutions.¹⁵³

OB researchers continue to debate the role of negative emotions and moods in decision making. One study suggested that people who are saddened by events may make the same decisions as before, while people who are angered by events might make stronger (though not necessarily better) choices than before.¹⁵⁴ Another study found that participants made choices reflecting more originality in a negative mood.¹⁵⁵ Still other research indicated that individuals in a negative mood may take higher risks than they do when in a positive mood.¹⁵⁶ Taken together, these and other studies suggest negative (and positive) emotions affect decision making but that there are other variables that require further research.¹⁵⁷

Creativity

As we see throughout this text, one strategic goal is to maximize employee productivity through creativity. Creativity is influenced by emotions and moods, but there are two schools of thought on the relationship. Much research suggests that people in good moods tend to be more creative than people in bad moods.¹⁵⁸ People in good moods produce more ideas and more options, and others think their ideas are original.¹⁵⁹ It seems that people experiencing positive moods or emotions are more flexible and open in their thinking, which may explain why they are more creative.¹⁶⁰ Supervisors should actively try to keep employees happy because doing so creates more good moods (employees like their leaders to encourage them and provide positive feedback on a job well done), which in turn leads people to be more creative.¹⁶¹

Some researchers, however, do not believe a positive mood makes people more creative. They argue that, when people are in positive moods, they may relax (“If I am in a good mood, things must be going okay, and I don’t need to think of new ideas”) and not engage in the critical thinking necessary for some forms of creativity.¹⁶² Individuals who worry more may perform better on creative tasks than those who worry less.

Determining which perspective is correct may lie in thinking of moods somewhat differently. Rather than looking at positive or negative affect, it is possible to conceptualize moods as active feelings like anger, fear, or elation and contrast these with deactivating moods like sorrow, depression, or serenity. All the activating moods, whether positive *or* negative, seem to lead to more creativity, whereas deactivating moods lead to less.¹⁶³ A study of 428 students found they performed best on a creative problem-solving task when they were fatigued, suggesting that tiredness may free the mind to consider novel solutions.¹⁶⁴

Ursula Burns, former CEO of Xerox, and the first woman to lead a Fortune 500 company, speaks at the Annual John Wooden Global Leadership Award Dinner. Burns' ability to engage with individuals and be "listener-in-chief" contributed to Xerox's massive growth during her tenure as CEO.

Source: Matt Sayles/Invision/AP/Shutterstock.



Motivation

Several studies have highlighted the importance of moods and emotions on motivation.¹⁶⁵ For instance, one study asked two groups of people to solve word puzzles. The first group saw a funny video clip intended to put them in a good mood first. The other group was not shown the clip and started working on the puzzles right away. The positive-mood group reported higher expectations of being able to solve the puzzles, worked harder at them, and did solve more as a result.¹⁶⁶ Another study looked at the moods of insurance sales agents.¹⁶⁷ Agents in a good mood were found to be more helpful toward their coworkers and felt better about themselves. These factors in turn led to superior performance in the form of higher sales and better supervisor reports of performance.

Giving people performance feedback—whether real or fake—influences their mood, which then influences their motivation.¹⁶⁸ A spiral can be created in which positive moods cause people to be more creative, leading to positive feedback from those observing their work.¹⁶⁹ The feedback further reinforces the positive mood, which makes people perform even better, and so on. Overall, the findings suggest a manager may enhance employee motivation—and performance—by encouraging good moods.

Leadership

Putting people in a good mood makes good sense. Leaders who focus on inspirational goals generate greater optimism, cooperation, and enthusiasm in employees, leading to more positive social interactions with coworkers and customers.¹⁷⁰ A study with Taiwanese military participants indicates that, by sharing emotions, transformational leaders inspire positive emotions in their followers that in turn lead to higher task performance.¹⁷¹

Leaders are perceived as more effective when they share positive emotions, and followers are more creative in a positive emotional environment. What about when leaders are sad? Research found that leader displays of sadness increased the analytic performance of followers, perhaps because followers attended more

closely to tasks to help the leaders.¹⁷² Another interesting study examined more than three hundred halftime locker room speeches from high school and college basketball teams, finding that leaders' sharing of negative emotions (e.g., anger) can help *improve* team performance. However, these emotions had to be at the right level of intensity—too negative and intense, and the display would backfire.¹⁷³ Leader anger, on the other hand, sparks both anxiety and anger in employees, paradoxically leading to higher work effort, but also to unethical retaliatory behavior, employees speaking up less, or employees leaving the organization.¹⁷⁴

Corporate executives know emotional content is critical for employees to buy into their vision of the company's future and accept change.¹⁷⁵ When higher-ups offer new visions, especially with vague or distant goals, it is often difficult for employees to accept the changes they will bring. By arousing emotions and linking them to an appealing vision, leaders may help managers and employees alike to accept change and feel connected to the new plan.

Negotiation

Several studies suggest that emotions play a role in negotiation,¹⁷⁶ but especially anger. In some situations, anger can benefit the negotiator as the opponent may conclude that the negotiator has conceded everything they can and so gives in.¹⁷⁷ In other cases, the opponent may try to diagnose why the negotiator is angry, leading to better joint concessions for both parties.¹⁷⁸ However, anger should be used selectively in negotiation: Angry negotiators who have less information or less power than their opponents have significantly worse outcomes,¹⁷⁹ such as angry negotiators who refuse to take the opponent's perspective (which could be useful information).¹⁸⁰ As in the use of any emotion, context matters. Displaying a negative emotion (such as anger) can be effective, but feeling angry, regretful, or prideful about your performance appears to impair future negotiations.¹⁸¹ Individuals who do poorly in negotiation experience negative emotions, develop negative perceptions of their counterparts, and are less willing to share information or be cooperative in future negotiations.¹⁸²

Customer Service

Workers' emotional states influence the level of customer service they give, which in turn influences levels of repeat business and customer satisfaction.¹⁸³ This result is primarily due to **emotional contagion**—the “catching” of emotions from others.¹⁸⁴ When someone experiences positive emotions and laughs and smiles at you, like when they are sending you a funny meme about retail life, you tend to respond positively. Of course, the opposite is true as well.

Studies indicate a matching effect between employee and customer emotions.¹⁸⁵ In the employee-to-customer direction, research finds that customers who catch the positive moods or emotions of employees (if they believe they are appropriate and authentic) become more satisfied and loyal to the organization, trust the organization to a greater degree, and even shop longer.¹⁸⁶ In the other direction, when an employee feels unfairly treated by a customer, it is harder for them to display the positive emotions the organization expects.¹⁸⁷ High-quality customer service makes demands on employees because it often puts them in a state of emotional dissonance, which can be damaging to the employee and the organization. Managers can interrupt negative contagion by fostering positive moods.

emotional contagion The process by which peoples' emotions are caused by the emotions of others.

Work–Life Conflict

There is good news and bad news about the relationship between moods and work–life conflict: Both are affected by work and home events. Ever hear the advice “Never take your work home with you,” meaning you should forget about work once you go home? That is easier said than done, especially now that so many

Toward a Better World

Scream Agency: Harnessing Customer Emotions to Bolster CSR

Some might believe that corporate social responsibility (CSR) “speaks for itself,” that it is “all about action,” and that the authentic practice of CSR involves modestly doing what is right without concern for the public’s response. Furthermore, some might believe that the default reaction from customers who *do* become aware of an organization’s CSR actions is “eye-rolling” and automatic dismissal of the effort as inauthentic. Adopting both mindsets would be a huge missed opportunity. First, not committing to telling the story of your company’s efforts is a missed opportunity to reach customers and convince them of the importance of the organization’s CSR mission. Second, when done well, CSR messaging can effectively connect with current and potential customers, foster loyalty, and even convince customers of the importance of the organizations’ CSR efforts. In other words, CSR messaging goes well beyond driving profits and can be a force for the greater good.

Meet Scream Agency, an advertising and public relations (PR) firm headquartered in Denver, Colorado. Its founder, Laura Ledermann, graduated from the University of Colorado Boulder with a CSR certificate. After graduating, Ledermann started Scream Agency to develop messaging and tell organizations’ stories in a way “that’s heard.” Like Ben & Jerry’s (spotlighted in the introductory chapter’s “Toward a Better World”), Scream is a B-corporation and is committed to meeting rigorous social and environmental performance as an integral part of its business model. Scream Agency has worked with many

companies to tell the story of their CSR efforts, including Hyatt Hotels, the American Automobile Association (AAA), and the Mellow Mushroom pizzeria chain. In Scream Agency’s manifesto, the company aspires to inspire brands to *be a change for good*. Their three-pronged mission is to be seen, be heard, and be good (with a heavy emphasis on the “good”). As a part of its strategy, Scream harnesses the power of emotions and EI to better connect with customers and employees. Scream’s approach involves four primary purposes: (1) identifying and becoming aware of the social problems to be solved, (2) preparing messaging to inform stakeholders, (3) convincing them of the solution, and (4) connecting with the audience’s emotions.

Although Scream’s approach makes sense in theory, is it evidence-based? First, research on Australian corporations active in climate change efforts suggests that marketing and CSR professionals play a crucial role. They contribute to the conversation and shape public opinion on the issue, making the difference between framing it as a challenge or an opportunity to make a difference. Second, messaging matters internally. For instance, Hurricane Katrina survivors experienced reduced job strain as a result of their organization’s response to the disaster as well as their compassionate messaging. Other studies have shown that CSR can lead employees to feel proud to work where they work and, as a result, less likely to leave for other organizations. Lastly, what about customers? Research demonstrates that the nature of CSR messaging has a direct

emotional impact on customers. For instance, a study of more than one thousand banking customers in Spain found that CSR communication led them to feel more positive emotions (e.g., happiness, pleasure, and delight) and want to identify more with their bank.

But there are challenges to this approach, as emotions do not always operate in the way we expect. For instance, managers’ and executives’ (lack of) emotions matter, too. CSR professionals often try to convince managers and executives of CSR’s business case. Although many may agree with the case, they are no less likely to do anything about it than managers who disagree. The business case and “rational justification” actually undermine moral emotions. Thus, executives are less likely to be moved or become angry at the CSR problem and are less likely to act. Also, we should understand that emotions are not an all-or-nothing proposition. Customers experience both positive and negative emotions. Positive emotions do not always lead to good outcomes. What one employee/customer/manager experiences may not be valid for the others. For instance, not everyone may agree with the organizations’ interpretation of the CSR problem and response, or some may question the organization’s credibility in dealing with the issue. Managing emotions in CSR messaging appears to be a challenge. However, professionals can take an adaptive approach to manage employee, manager, and customer emotions to realize the organization’s CSR mission.¹⁸⁸

people are working from home. The good news is that a positive mood at work can apparently spill over to your off-work hours, and a negative mood at work can be restored to a positive mood after a break. Several studies have shown that people who had a good day at work tend to be in a better mood at home that evening, and vice versa.¹⁸⁹ Other research has found that, although people do emotionally take their work home with them, by the next day the effect is usually gone.¹⁹⁰ The bad news is that the moods of your household may interfere with yours. As you might expect, one study found that if one member of a couple was in a negative mood during the workday, the negative mood spilled over to the spouse at night.¹⁹¹

Unethical Workplace Behaviors

Anyone who has spent much time in an organization realizes people can behave in ways that violate established norms and threaten the organization, its members, or both. As we saw in the introductory chapter, these unethical behaviors (also referred to as deviant behaviors) can do a great deal of harm in organizations and often take the form of counterproductive work behaviors (CWBs).¹⁹² They can be traced to negative emotions and can take many forms. People who feel negative emotions are more likely than others to engage in short-term deviant behavior at work, such as gossiping or excessively surfing the Internet instead of working,¹⁹³ although negative emotions can also lead to more serious forms of CWB.

For instance, envy is an emotion that occurs when you resent someone for having something you do not have but strongly desire—such as a better work assignment, larger office, or higher salary. It can lead to malicious deviant behaviors. An envious employee could undermine other employees and take all the credit for things others accomplished. Angry people look for other people to blame for their bad mood, interpret other people's behavior as hostile, and have trouble considering others' points of view.¹⁹⁴ It is also not hard to see how these thought processes can lead directly to verbal or physical aggression.

One study found that anger correlated with more aggressive CWBs such as abuse against others and production deviance, while sadness did not. Neither anger nor sadness predicted workplace withdrawal, which suggests that managers need to take employee expressions of anger seriously; employees may stay with an organization and continue to act aggressively toward others.¹⁹⁵ CWBs can also lead to a negative emotional spiral, with some employees experiencing negative emotions *after* they engage in CWBs as well.¹⁹⁶ These negative emotions can be exacerbated due to social media, as one study demonstrated that following a catastrophic event at an organization, negative emotions resonated through Facebook like an echo chamber.¹⁹⁷ Once aggression starts, it is likely that other people will become angry and aggressive, so the stage is set for a serious escalation of negative behavior. Therefore, managers need to stay connected with their employees to gauge emotions and emotional intensity levels. But be careful—although many companies have started keeping close track of employees' emotions and moods through surveys, and even by analyzing their daily email and chat data, many employees find this to be an invasion of privacy.¹⁹⁸

Safety and Injury at Work

Bad moods can contribute to injury at work in several ways.¹⁹⁹ Individuals in negative moods tend to be more anxious, which can make them less able to cope effectively with hazards. A person who is always fearful will be more pessimistic about the effectiveness of safety precautions because they feel they will just get hurt anyway, or might panic or freeze up when confronted with a threatening situation. Negative moods also make people more distractible, and distractions can obviously lead to careless behaviors. For instance, two studies of migrant workers and expatriate military personnel found that negative, longing feelings of

homesickness predicted both job performance and safety behaviors.²⁰⁰ Research relating negative affectivity to increased injuries at work suggests employers might improve health and safety (and reduce costs) by ensuring that workers are not engaged in potentially dangerous activities when they are in a bad mood.

Summary

Emotions and moods are both a part of the affective experience at work. But they are also different—moods are more general and longer-lived, where emotions are discrete and short-lived. Together, these feelings and experiences comprise workers' positive and negative affect, essential concepts to describe the emotional nature of work. Discrete emotions serve various functions, and OB researchers categorize them differently. For instance, some emotions are ethically charged in response to moral situations. Others serve more basic functions in response to everyday events. The time of day, stressful events, and sleep patterns are some of the factors that influence emotions and moods. Varieties in the experience of emotions and mood highlight that sometimes employers establish norms for desired or appropriate emotions on the job. The disconnect between one's felt emotions and displayed emotions and the effort workers expend to maintain them can have several implications for employee well-being and productivity. Affectively charged work events often trigger these emotions. Affective events theory suggests that these events lead to emotional reactions, which impact job satisfaction and job performance. What can better equip workers and managers to deal with these unpredictable work experiences? Research on EI and emotion regulation suggests the competencies people can draw upon to manage their (and others') emotions and moods at work. Indeed, affect, emotions, and moods at work have substantial implications for several aspects of OB. The "Affective Revolution" is still running strong to this day.

Implications for Managers

- Recognize that emotions, mood, and affect are a natural part of the workplace, and good management does not mean creating an emotion-free environment.
- Emotional experience is volatile and unpredictable. Just as we often have trouble predicting what happens in work life, so, too, do we have trouble predicting our emotional responses to what happens. But we *can* attempt to regulate how we react to the events and respond to others' emotions.
- As a manager, consider how employees may react when announcing a new policy or taking action that affects them. You may be the catalyst for an affective event that has emotional consequences. Because of this, you should try to anticipate how you could effectively respond to their reactions.
- Surface acting and emotional suppression are generally ineffective strategies for managing ones' emotions. Deep acting, natural emotional expression, and cognitive reappraisal may be more effective strategies.
- Work to develop an understanding of the role of emotions and moods to significantly improve your ability to explain and regulate your own and others' behavior.
- To foster effective decision making, creativity, and motivation, model positive emotions and moods as much as is authentically possible.
- In the service sector, encourage authentic, appropriate positive displays of emotion, which are "contagious" to customers and improve service interactions and negotiations.

Sometimes Yelling Is for Everyone's Good

POINT

Anger is discussed throughout this chapter for a reason: It is an important emotion. There are benefits to expressing anger. For one, research indicates that only employees who are committed to their organizations tend to express their anger, and generally only to leaders who created the situation. This type of expression of anger could lead to positive organizational change. Second, suppressed anger can lower job satisfaction and lead to a feeling of hopelessness about things improving.

Even with these findings, we hear a lot about not responding emotionally to work challenges. Work cultures teach us to avoid showing any anger at all lest we be seen as poor workers or, worse, unprofessional or even deviant or violent. While, of course, there are times when the expression of anger is harmful or unprofessional. We have taken this view so far that we now teach people to suppress perfectly normal emotions and to ignore the effectiveness of some emotional expression.

Emerging research shows that suppressing anger takes a terrible internal toll on individuals. One Stanford University study found, for example, that when individuals were asked to wear a poker face during the showing of a movie clip depicting the atomic bombings of Japan during World War II, they were much more stressed in conversations after the video. Other research shows that college students who suppress emotions like anger have more trouble making friends and are more likely to be depressed, and that employees who suppress anger feel more stressed by work.

For the good of organizations and their employees, we should encourage people not to hold back their emotions but to share them constructively.

COUNTERPOINT

Yes, anger is a common emotion. But it is also a toxic one for the giver and the receiver. Angry outbursts can compromise the heart and contribute to diabetes, among other ill effects. The experience of another's anger and its close correlate, hostility, is also linked to many counterproductive behaviors in organizations. The Bureau of Labor Statistics estimates that 15 percent of fatal workplace injuries result from workplace violence. That is why many organizations are implementing conflict management training programs.

To prevent violence and counterproductive behavior, many companies develop policies that prohibit conduct such as yelling, shouting profanities, and making hostile gestures. Others institute conflict management training programs. These programs come in a variety of forms and cover a wide range of topics. They often involve one-day workshops, small-group facilitations, or one-on-one sessions. The benefit of these programs is that they can help employees who become explosively angry and those who exhibit passive-aggressive behavior that is also harmful to an organization. In addition to these programs, developing strong employee relations can help prevent these types of behaviors from occurring in the first place. Careful hiring that considers a candidate's demeanor and communication style in addition to their experience is also key.

In the end, everyone wins when organizations seek to diminish both the experience and the expression of anger at work. The work environment becomes less threatening and stressful to employees and customers. Employees are likely to feel safer, and the angry employee is often helped as well.²⁰¹

CHAPTER REVIEW

QUESTIONS FOR REVIEW

- 4-1** How are emotions different from moods?
- 4-2** What are the sources of emotions and moods?
- 4-3** What impact does emotional labor have on employees?
- 4-4** What is affective events theory?
- 4-5** What is emotional intelligence?
- 4-6** What are some strategies for emotion regulation?
- 4-7** How do you apply concepts about emotions and moods to specific OB issues?